Fatehpur. Father Monserrate lived in Fatehpur for several months and describes it as a city of spectacle and riches: with its 'Circus [for] elephants fight[s], gladiatorial displays' and polo matches; with its massive reservoir, cooling the breeze that blew over its stone palaces; with its baths and great bazaar, 'filled with an astonishing quantity of every description of merchandise, and with countless people' – and, 'overlooking the whole city', Akbar's large and 'very beautiful' audience hall.

A decade or so before Monserrate arrived, as Akbar supervised the building of his city of victory – a painting shows him talking to a mason while all around men cut stone, saw wood, dig the ground[6] – the emperor had won, once again.

But also, it may be that he was getting bored.

The beginning of Akbar's seventeenth year as padishah (1572–73) includes an odd bit of news. Muzaffar Khan, who, along with Todar Mal, had been trying these past years to bring some coherence to Akbar's finances and check 'embezzlement [by] the slaves of gold',[7] had become the bane of Akbar's nobility. A popular chronogram for the date of his promotion to vizier was '*zaalim*', tyrant.[8] Now, it seems, Muzaffar Khan had fallen foul of the emperor, too. It was not a lapse in financial probity,[9] however, that had upset Akbar, but lack of grace when losing at ludo.

Chaupar, or parcheesi, an early and more complex form of this dice game, was Akbar's latest obsession. He played it 'with keenness',[10] writes Abul Fazl, which is an understatement. Akbar's chaupar parties were almost as deranged as his musth elephant rides. They could go on for months – up to 200 players compelled to move from game to game, and no one allowed to go home.[11] If Muzaffar Khan 'behaved in a savage . . . manner'[12] during one of these marathons, it is hardly surprising – but the Mughal court was no longer the kind of place in which a crochety Tardi Beg, for example, could grumble freely. Once, Akbar may have greeted a visiting ambassador with louche casualness; he may have run about the roof of his old Agra fort bare-headed for all to see – but that old fort was long gone, and of that old Akbar, too, little trace remained.

This new padishah took protocol – particularly the protocol of deference – very seriously. The previous year, a chieftain who came drunk to court was tied to a horse's tail and paraded in public. Now, Muzaffar Khan was